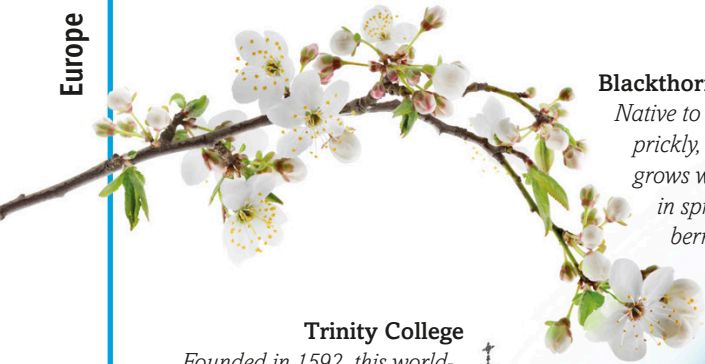




Ireland

Europe



Blackthorn

Native to Ireland, this prickly, hardy shrub grows white flowers in spring and black berries in fall.

Trinity College

Founded in 1592, this world-famous university in Dublin has educated many celebrated Irish writers, including Bram Stoker and Oscar Wilde.



Gaelic football

In this action-packed Irish team sport, players can kick, catch, or throw the ball.



The bodhrán is a type of Irish drum.



Folk instruments

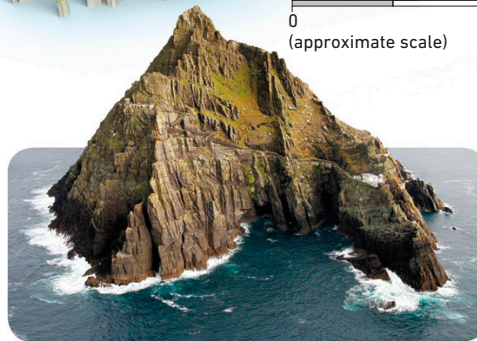
Folk music is embedded in Irish tradition. The main instrument is the violin, also known as a fiddle.



The capital **Dublin** is also Ireland's largest city and home to about one-third of the population.

Irish Sea

Step-dancing
Performed since the 19th century, this traditional Irish dance form involves a straight body and fast foot movements.



Skellig Islands

Off the southwest coast of Ireland are two rocky islets providing a safe haven for seabirds such as gannets and puffins.



- 27,132 sq miles (70,273 sq km)
- 5.2 million
- Dublin
- English, Irish

Once part of the United Kingdom, **southern Ireland**, where most people are Roman Catholic, **became independent in 1921**. **Northern Ireland**, where people are mainly Protestant, remains part of the UK.